



TIMOTHY SHAVA

TUTORIAL

ChatGPT for Beginners

From zero to confident daily use in seven short chapters, with practice exercises.

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Chapter 1 - What ChatGPT is (and isn't)

ChatGPT is a program you talk to in normal language. You type what you want; it answers. It has read a huge amount of text and is very good at writing, summarising, explaining, planning and brainstorming. It is not the internet, it is not always right, and it doesn't know your private information unless you tell it.

- Great at: drafting, rewriting, summarising, explaining, planning, ideas.
- Weak at: very recent news, precise maths on big numbers, facts it 'sounds sure' about - always sanity-check names, dates and figures.
- Rule 1: talk to it like a smart assistant, not a search box.

Exercise 1

Type: "Explain how ChatGPT works, as if to someone who has never used a computer." Then type: "Now in one sentence." Notice how you can steer it.

Chapter 2 - Getting set up

Go to chat.openai.com in your phone or computer browser, or install the ChatGPT app from your app store. Create a free account with your email. The free plan is enough for everything in this guide. Claude (claude.ai) and Gemini (gemini.google.com) work the same way - every lesson here works in all three.

Chapter 3 - Your first real conversations

The quality of the answer follows the quality of the question. Compare:

- Weak: "write email boss"
- Strong: "Write a short, polite email to my boss asking to move Thursday's meeting to Friday morning, because I'll be at the clinic. Keep it under 80 words."

The strong version tells it four things: the task, the audience, the reason, and the limit. That pattern - task, audience, details, limits - is 80% of prompting.

Exercise 2

Take a real message you need to send this week. Ask ChatGPT to draft it using the pattern above. Then say 'make it warmer' or 'make it shorter' until it sounds like you.

Chapter 4 - The follow-up is the superpower

Beginners treat every answer as final. Experienced users treat it as a first draft. You can always say: 'shorter', 'simpler', 'more formal', 'give me 3 more options', 'now as a table', 'you missed X, add it'. The conversation remembers what came before, so build on it instead of starting over.

Exercise 3

Ask: "Give me 10 dinner ideas with chicken and rice." Then: "Only ones under 30 minutes." Then: "Write a shopping list for the first two." Three follow-ups, no restarting.

Chapter 5 - Everyday uses that stick

- Messages and emails: draft, soften, shorten, translate.
- Understanding: 'explain this letter/contract/error message in plain English'.
- Planning: budgets, trips, study timetables, event checklists.
- Learning: 'teach me [skill] in 10 lessons, one per day, quiz me as we go'.
- Documents: turn rough notes into reports, minutes, applications.

Exercise 4

Pick the one from the list you'd use most. Do it now with something real from your week.

Chapter 6 - Staying safe and honest

- Don't paste passwords, ID numbers or anyone's private details.
- Check facts that matter - AI states wrong things confidently.
- Anything you sign or send is yours: read it before it leaves you.
- For work, know your employer's policy before pasting company documents.

Chapter 7 - Cheat sheet

KEEP THIS PAGE

THE PATTERN: [task] + [audience] + [details] + [limits]

STEERING WORDS: shorter - simpler - warmer - more formal -
as a table - as bullet points - 3 options - step by step

FIXERS: 'You missed X' - 'That's wrong because Y' -
'Ask me questions before answering'

GOLDEN RULE: it's a first draft, not a final answer.

Questions or a file problem? Email info@timothyshava.com or WhatsApp +263 77 283 7385 within 7 days and it will be sorted.